

CODA: ALL I REALLY NEED TO KNOW ABOUT QUALITATIVE RESEARCH I LEARNED IN HIGH SCHOOL

The 2016 Qualitative High graduation commencement address

Johnny Saldaña

Alma mater

(the Valedictorian of Qualitative High School, dressed in a black graduation gown and cap, steps to the podium; he addresses the audience)

VALEDICTORIAN: Could we all please rise, as you're able, for the singing of our school's alma mater. We all know the melody, right? I'll warm up to get us started; join in when you catch on.

(the Valedictorian leads the audience as they hum through the melody of "Daisy")

Everyone, now:

(slides: song lyrics; the audience sings to the tune of "Daisy")

Qual High, Qual High,
Oh, what a lovely name!
Life is our lab,
Researching is our game.
Whether narrative, codes, or theory,
We love to do inquiry.
And how we write
Into the night.
Hail to thee, hallowed school,
Qual High!

(Valedictorian shouts: Second verse!)

Qual High, Qual High,
Loyal are we to you.
We're word crazy,
Some of the chosen few.
We don't really crunch statistics,
We're more about heuristics.
And we'll not rest
Until we're the best.
Hail to thee, hallowed school,
Qual High!
(applause and cheers)
Thank you. Please be seated.

Welcome

(slide: graduation cap and diploma)

Principal Denzin, distinguished faculty and staff, parents, family members, friends, and students of Qualitative High: Welcome, and thank you for the honor of selecting me as valedictorian for Qual High's 2016 graduation commencement address.

Curriculum

We've all worked hard for our high school degrees by studying lots of different subjects in qualitative inquiry. We had a great curriculum and set of classes at Qual High with some really outstanding teachers. Just in my senior year alone, I took:

(slides: class titles)

Period 1, Grounded Theory, with that teacher that everybody loves,
Ms. Charmaz.

Period 2, Phenomenology, with the mellow and laid back Mr. Vagle.

Period 3, Ethnography, with Qual High's sweetheart of a teacher, Ms. Tracy.

Period 4, Case Studies, with my soulful mentor, Ms. De la Garza.

Then Lunch, which usually consisted of either barbeque or fried chicken.

Period 5, Autoethnography, with that rockin' dude, Mr. Poulos.

Period 6, CAQDAS Computer Lab, with my gal-pal Ms. Jackson.

Period 7, Ont-Ep, or Ontologies and Epistemologies, with the brilliant
Ms. Mirka.

And Period 8, with Mr. Creswell, AP Mixed Methods – or, as we jokingly
liked to call it, the “mixed meth lab.”

(slide: dancers on stage)

We had great after school extracurricular activities, too, like Poetic Inquiry and Arts-Based Research. These programs were after school for no credit because, you know, they're frills. But our award-winning Qual High drama club did put on some pretty outstanding play productions this year, like:

(slides: play productions)

A Datum in the Sun, Category on a Hot Tin Roof, To Code a Mockingbird, the children's theatre touring show of *The Wizard of Observation*, and the club's annual musicals: *The Phenomenology of the Opera* and *Fieldwork on the Roof*.

(slides: high school proms)

But at Qual High it wasn't all work. We also had fun, like at the school's annual proms with our wonderful themes: "Enchanted Ethnography," "A Million Case Studies," and "Grounded Theory under the Sea."

Now, you may think that there's more to learn after we receive our diplomas today. But, in a way, all we really need to know about qualitative research we learned in high school.

Cliques

(slides: high school cliques)

For example, at Qual High we learned that there are cliques – social groups of like-minded tribes who cluster into categories of affinity such as the arts-based researchers, the autoethnographers, the mixed methods researchers, the grounded theorists, and the poststructuralists.

(video clip: the cliques and cafeteria scene from Mean Girls: www.youtube.com/watch?v=IVhfrUkH5JY)

(slides: high school cliques)

Cliques usually sat together at their respective lunchroom tables and shop-talked passionately about what they shared in common. We naturally gravitate to those with whom we share a common interest. And, it made us feel as if we belonged to a little community. But remember at lunch how, in our cliques, we sometimes talked smack about others sitting at different tables? Ethnographers would glance toward the phenomenologists and think, "I wonder what it is they do, exactly." Poststructuralists would sneer at the grounded theorists and think, "Losers!" Mixed-methods researchers would glance suspiciously at the arts-based inquiry table and whisper among themselves, "Well, yeah, but it's not *real* research."

What we learned is that Qual High, like life, has cliques. And though some of us crossed borders now and then because of our different interests, there seems to be a tightly controlled mind-set in some of these camps, with their leaders or big dogs who set the tone for the rest of the group. There'll be people in your clique who'll be your best friends forever and ever, and others from different cliques who'll think that they're just too cool for you. We were told by our teachers that we're one big global community and that we should all learn to get along with each other. But at Qual High, we've been taught to compete with our raging hormones of professional disagreement, fighting in the parking lot or locker room over who's got the biggest paradigm.

Rivalry

(slide: high school football players)

Now, sometimes competition can be a good thing. We had great team rivalry with the alternative school, Post-Qual High, with their post-football games at their post-stadium, watching their post-students in the post-stands post-applauding their post-marching band making post-formations on the post-field, with their post-cheerleaders and post-pep squad excitedly waving their post-pom-poms, rallying around the post-football team's post-quarterback making post-touchdowns at the post-goal posts.

(slide: math Olympics winners)

We had great team rivalry with Quant High, too, even though they always kicked our butts at science fairs and math Olympics. After all, their school motto was *(slide)*, "*Gloria in numero*" – "Strength in Numbers." But let's not forget our school motto *(slide)*: "*Ut intellegas omnia*" – "To Understand Is Everything." Yeah, Quant High may calculate the mean, but at Qual High *we* calculate *meaning*.

Literature

(slides: libraries and book covers)

In literature classes, we read the great masterworks of the field, like *The Presentation of Self in Everyday Life*, *The Discovery of Grounded Theory*, and *Naturalistic Inquiry*. In secret, a few of us even snuck off and delved into the banned books section to get off on such titles as *Sick Societies* and *Tearoom Trade*. We learned a lot from our teachers about the classics. They felt it was important to know our literary history, our scholarly roots.

Admittedly, I originally thought that these moldy-oldies wouldn't have anything to say to me now. But after reading books by Ina Corinne Brown, Clifford

Geertz, and Elliot Liebow – not just reading *about* them in a research handbook but reading what *they themselves* actually wrote – it made me realize how rich our field is, how insightful our ancestors were, and how our own work today is truly built on their foundations. And just because we can Amazon.com or Wikipedia our way through a literature review these days, doesn't mean we should ignore the genius of what's already been discovered and written about social life. I encourage my incoming and current classmates: Don't just stick to what's been published in the last five to ten years. Pick up a 20th-century classic now and then. Read it. Learn for yourself why it's considered a masterpiece.

Composition

Now, reading was hard but writing was harder – even the faculty admitted how tough it was to write qualitatively.

(video clip: the writer's struggle scene from Hamlet 2: www.youtube.com/watch?v=hg10aV0uPQk)
(slides: people writing)

Rivalry wasn't just with other schools, it was even amongst ourselves. Sometimes we felt bullied when a senior mocked us because we couldn't grasp an ontology, or when we hadn't read the latest journal issue, or if we hadn't cited their work in our most recent report. Manuscript submissions were the worst – when our articles that we worked so hard on were ripped apart by badass peer reviewers who tore down our self-esteem. It was qualitative hazing, of sorts – a ritual we had to go through to be accepted into the publications club. But many of us will never forget that day when we finally made it into the journal of life!

(slide: the journal cover for “Qualitative Inquiry”)

Teachers kept telling us to “find” our voice. And, that journey took a bit of time. But what I eventually learned at Qual High was that I didn't need to “find” my voice – all I needed to do was to *trust* it.

CAQDAS lab

(slides: CAQDAS screenshots)

I did OK in reading and writing qualitatively, but math and science were not my strong suit. That's probably why I flunked CAQDAS computer lab and had to retake the course – twice. I remember going up to Ms. Jackson one day after my program crashed and whining, “Ms. Jackson – digital tools are, like, *hard*!” She looked me straight in the eye and said, “Johnny, it's not the software that's holding

you back; it's your fear." Nevertheless, she placed me in the freshman remedial CAQDAS class. But even there, I had a very hard time trying to figure things out, even after learning that stupid "Qualitative Software Song" – remember it? Sing along with me, if you do:

(slides: song lyrics; sung to the tune of "The ABC Song")

AnSWR, AQUAD, Qualrus, CAT,
ATLAS.ti, Dedoose, INTERACT,
Transana, NVivo,
V-Note, WordStat, Quirkos, oh,
MAXQDA, DiscoverText,
HyperRESEARCH, none of these complex.

(slides: CAQDAS screenshots)

But they *were* complex – to me, at least. Some students aced these courses: tech-head whiz kids who got it and knew all the right functions to click while I was still struggling to learn the difference between a code and a node. But I didn't give up, and I came out with an A-minus – the qual nerd's "F" I'll admit there's still a lot more to learn, and you're never too old to learn, right? Like Ms. Jackson said – it's not the software that's holding us back; it's our fear.

Driving

(slides: high school drivers)

Speaking of fear, high school was also the time we learned how to drive. It was a major achievement to get that license from the PhD-DMV. In dissertation driving class, we were scared, at first, to get behind that wheel, armed only with our master's learning permit and a committee chair yelling at us, "You're going too fast! Slow down, slow down, *slow down!*" But we paid careful attention to the road as we sped down Seminar Street and Doctoral Drive, following the rules and braking quickly when danger lay ahead. We'd steer and swerve and not accidentally step on the fast-track gas pedal and run head on into committee members standing on a sidewalk, even through there were times when some of us really, really wanted to. Oh, but what an achievement, to finally get that license from the PhD-DMV! Yeah, there are student car loan payments to make for what seems like an eternity, but now, we can go anywhere we want.

Detention

Admittedly, a few of us did spend a little time in in-school and after-school detention.

(video clip: the detention monitor's opening instructions scene in The Breakfast Club: www.youtube.com/watch?v=Z2WZrxuwDhs)

(slides: high school detention)

Detention wasn't all that bad, though. It was a time and place to reflect, to reflex, to refract. A time when the suspension monitor forced us to write analytic memos on our deviant actions and what they all mean. The bad boys and bad girls of Qual High who refused, rejected, avoided, and failed, who wouldn't put up with anyone's othering or interactional BS, critically theorized about the oppressive panopticons of power and the stigma of our presentations of self in this total institutional asylum of a school.

The badasses of Qual High even had a nickname for their gang – the Outliers. The police would sometimes catch them spray painting graffiti on school walls such as *(slides)*: “POWER TO THE PARTICIPANTS,” “N = ME!”, and “FOUCAULT? FOUCYOU!”

Deviance, though, can sometimes be a good thing. It means you're straying away from the norm, challenging the status quo, and presenting an alternative perspective on life. The time it becomes a problem, however, is when resistance transforms into intellectual obstruction. It becomes a problem when ontological defiance transforms into epistemological bullying and axiological manipulation. Walk your own path, but don't peer-pressure or kidnap others along the way. Butting heads with someone may get yours bitten off. As we were taught in our Ethics class *(slide)*: “Do no harm, but take no shit.”

(aside)

Sorry, Principal Denzin.

Teachers

Us students had a tough time at Qual High, but we also know our teachers did, too.

(video clip: the literature class scene from 10 Things I Hate About You: www.youtube.com/watch?v=H_3eOtD_0GA)

(slides: high school teachers interacting with students)

Sometimes when I passed by the faculty lounge, I heard teachers saying things behind the door such as, “I can't teach my students how to think,” or “He wouldn't know a paradigm if it fell on his head,” and “What do those kids expect me to do, pull a grounded theory out of my butt?” Some teachers made darn sure that when it came to research methods, it was either their way or the highway, while others nurtured and encouraged us to find our own ways of working.

Perhaps you're hoping some of us will become the next Arlie Russell Hochschild or the next Erving Goffman. But maybe, just maybe, I want to be the next Barbara Ehrenreich or the next Dwight Conquergood. Or maybe I just want to be the *first* Johnny Saldaña. After we leave Qual High, the methodological decisions are up to us.

Teachers: We appreciate what you did for us, shaping, sharpening, and challenging our minds. We know that qualitative teachers work hard, put in long hours, and you're grossly underpaid. But we'll never forget what you did for us. You taught us how to look at life in new and different ways. You taught us how to think for ourselves, to not be swept away by what's trendy in the field. And you taught us to strive for rigor, credibility, and trustworthiness in everything we do. You have influenced and affected our lives for the better, and we are eternally grateful to you.

Sex

All we really need to know about qualitative research we learned in high school. For example, we learned about sex.

(video clip: the fake bedroom sex scene from Easy A: www.youtube.com/watch?v=QGIQQBEj9uU)

Oh yeah, our classes in qualitative health care taught us about the biological and reproductive aspects of being human, but the teenagers in us fooled around. We even had labels for it, too (slides):

- 1st base: Codes
- 2nd base: Categories
- 3rd base: Theories

It was a time to naturally experiment, to discover what turned us on. I'm not ashamed to admit it, we all did it. When we should have been constructing matrices, flow charts, and diagrams for mixed-methods class, sometimes I was locked away in my bedroom under the covers – writing autoethnography.

(slides: terms)

But, I mean, let's face it – in high school, sex was all around us: gender studies, women's studies, masculinity studies, feminist theory, queer theory, trans studies – it seemed as if every course in junior year was about sex, sex, sex. I mean, come on, the terms our teachers used: *raw data*, *horizontalization*, *probing*, *oral history*, *thick description*. Some days I didn't know the difference between an IRB and an STD.

Qual High was a magical period, though, for first-time experiences: Losing our virginity on the first day of fieldwork; that awkward moment of silence during our first formal interview; and the heartbreaking crush of our first journal article rejection letter.

Yet through it all, we were taught to analyze responsibly in ethics class, to practice safe research. And we learned that no matter what our methodological preference or orientation – qualitative, quantitative, or mixed – we are all loved. We are OK, just as we are.

The real world

(slides: people in despair)

People say that high school prepares you for the real world. And, unfortunately, the real world waiting for us consists of bad things like government accountability, massive cuts to higher education, restricted or conditional funds for our research, unsolved social problems all around us, and some really, really stupid people with way too much money and power.

(slide: “Hope”)

But we’re a resourceful graduating class – we have to be. We have skills that can change the world. We have knowledge about the way things work that can make a significant impact on others.

Life learnings

All we really need to know about qualitative research we learned in high school. But like they taught me in Constructivism class, I acknowledge that my perspective is not the only one that exists. So, I asked my Facebook friends from our graduating class what *they* learned at Qual High, and this is what they told me:

(slides: high school yearbook photos from the 1950s to today)

Being a researcher means to find your passion and follow it. Getting involved in projects you love makes life worth living. If you have an interest in a research topic, it’s up to you, and only you, to pursue it. You can let research happen to you, or you can make research happen. Other scholars may come and go and be supportive or not, but it’s your responsibility to be in the world, so it’s your responsibility to know the world.

Research isn't always as hard as we make it out to be. Maybe you don't want people to know how dumb you *think* you are, or how smart you *really* are. Nobody, not even you, will remember in a few short years the stupid things you said in a seminar that you made you feel like hiding away forever. And even if you're a senior researcher with a kick-ass publications record, you're not entitled to anything; if it's worth having, then it's worth working for. Teachers aren't always right; sometimes students are.

Yeah, there were some mean bullies at Qual High who shoved us into methodological lockers. It made us want to build walls to protect ourselves. But we survived. Life goes on after we graduate from Qual High. There are many more great inquiries ahead. Life isn't always fair, but *you* can be. Put good into the world every day. Despite what our teachers told us, these weren't "the best years of our lives," because it gets *better*.

If you're new to Qual High, not fitting in is OK; everyone's insecure. Find a paradigmatic place where you can be who *you* need to be. If you get tired of grounded theory, then write an autoethnography. If you're bored with generating codes and categories, then write a data poem. Reinvent yourself.

Good research colleagues, good friends, are the most important thing. Don't put your heroes on pedestals, though, because it'll hurt really bad when they come crashing down. It's better to be you than someone else. Like our teachers taught us in Autoethnography class: "You can't learn how to tell someone else's story until you first learn how to tell your own."

The future

High school is the time for the search for our identities. And some of us have already found a focus as grounded theorists, arts-based researchers, mixed methodologists, and so on. But you know what? That may change in the future. We are adolescents – or dare I say, young adults – with a lot more growing up to do. There are many opportunities ahead of us, and we need to be ready for them in any way we can.

(slide: forks in the road)

Like baseball great Yogi Berra said, "When you come to a fork in the road, take it!" We need to keep ourselves open to *all* quests for knowledge. We'll interview when we need to, we'll observe when we need to. We'll crunch numbers when we need to, we'll think with theory when we need to. We'll write a poem when we need to, we'll compose an autoethnography when we need to. We'll code when we need to, we'll categorize when we need to, we'll use a CAQDAS software program when we need to. We need to know how to do it *all* – because we never know what our futures hold.

Farewell

(slide: Qual High motto)

“*Ut intellegas omnia*” – “To Understand Is Everything.”

(slide: graduation cap and diploma)

Qual High class of 2016, we did it! We’ve gotten through, and we’ve received our diplomas. We’re research geeks, and damn proud of it. So let’s go out there, raise some qualitative hell, and change the world! Thank you, and *congratulations*!

(recessional music: Elgar’s “Pomp and Circumstance”: www.youtube.com/watch?v=Q0PHWKRFgZ0)